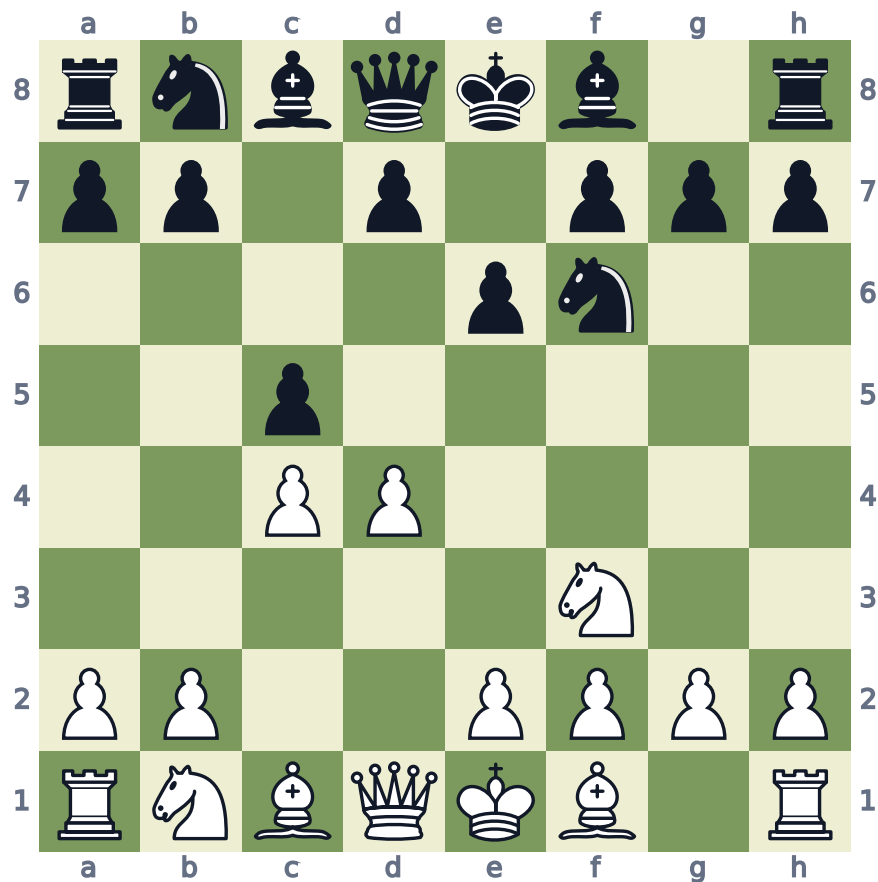


1.d4 Tactics, Traps, and Defensive Resources

Opening geometry, poisoned pawns, central blows, trapped pieces, and safe refutations



Learn recurring tactical mechanisms from 1.d4 positions while separating sound combinations from hope-chess traps.

36 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Learn recurring tactical mechanisms from 1.d4 positions while separating sound combinations from hope-chess traps.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 36 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

A trap is useful only when you know the safe response to its threat.

PRINCIPLE 2

Loose pieces and uncastled kings make central moves forcing.

PRINCIPLE 3

Pins on f6 and c3 can change the legality of central captures.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Queen sorties must be tested against development with tempo.

PRINCIPLE 5

The best refutation often returns material and completes development.

PRINCIPLE 6

Calculate the opponent's most forcing resource before committing.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

TACTICAL PROTOCOL

How to solve opening tactics without guessing

STEP 1

Update the board after the last move: new attacks, lost defenses, and opened lines.

STEP 2

List every legal check, major capture, and direct threat for both sides.

STEP 3

Identify loose pieces, pinned defenders, overloaded pieces, and exposed kings.

STEP 4

Calculate the opponent's strongest forcing reply before choosing.

STEP 5

At the endpoint, count material and evaluate king safety, development, and center.

TACTICAL TEST 01 OF 36

Blumenfeld Gambit



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 02 OF 36

Benoni e5 break

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 03 OF 36

Benoni queenside break

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

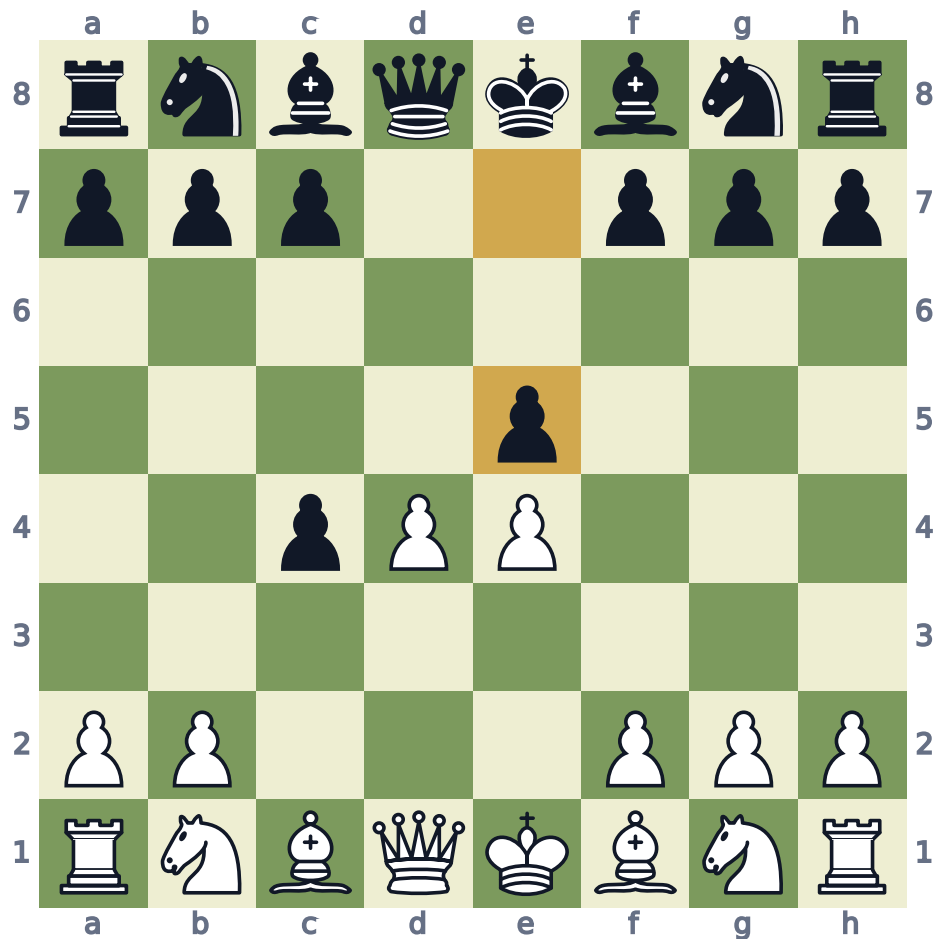
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 04 OF 36

Early e4 in the QGA

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

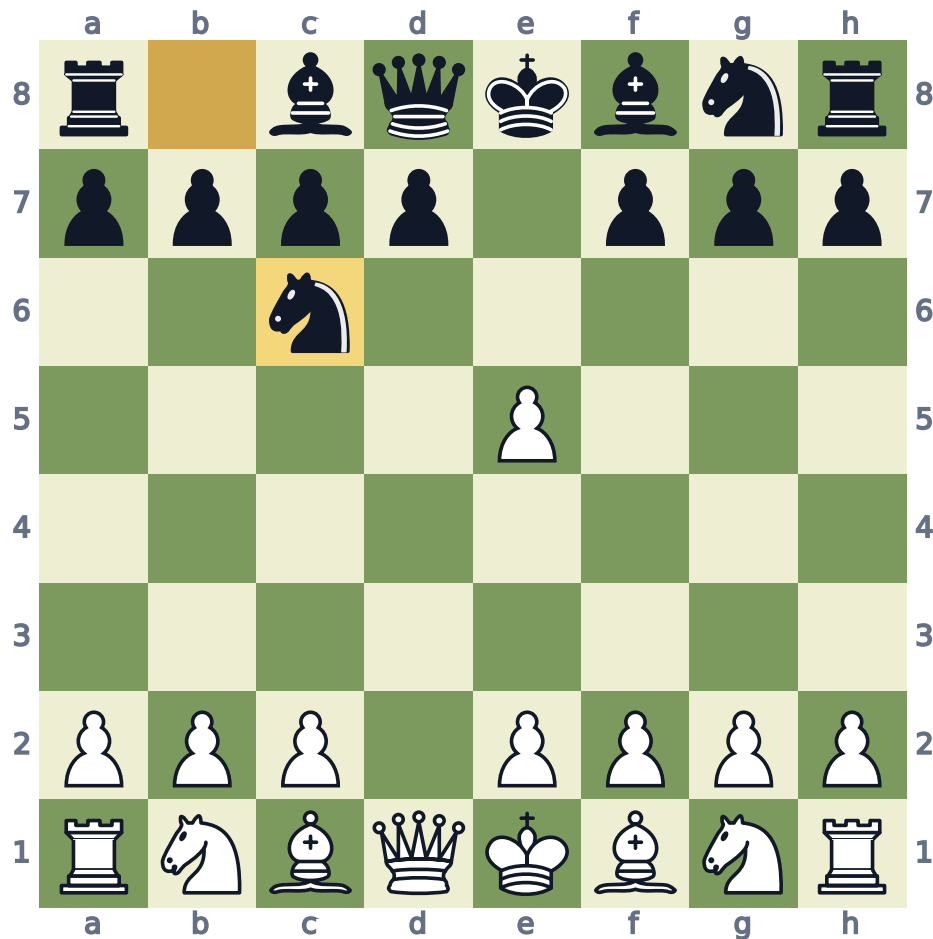
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 05 OF 36

Englund Gambit



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 06 OF 36

Tarrasch Defense



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 07 OF 36

Fianchetto alternative



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 08 OF 36

Closed Catalan core



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

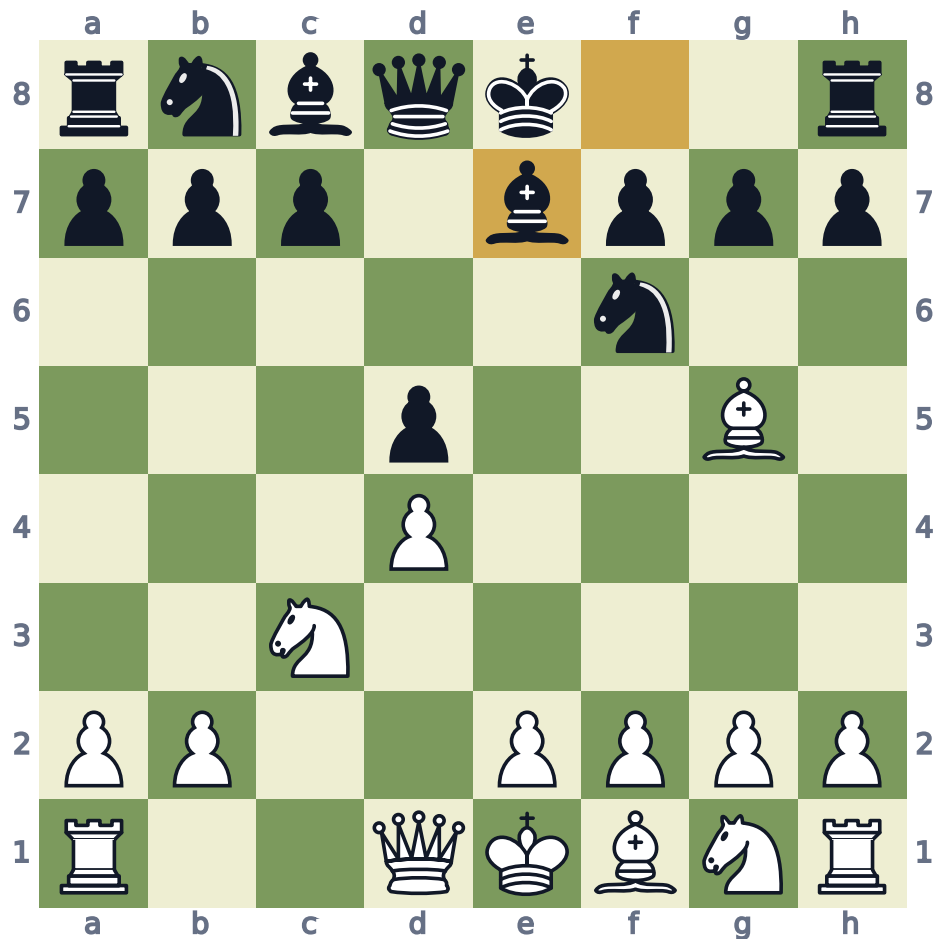
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 09 OF 36

Minority attack setup



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 10 OF 36

English Defense



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 11 OF 36

Marshall Defense



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 12 OF 36

Baltic Defense

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 13 OF 36

Baltic Defense

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

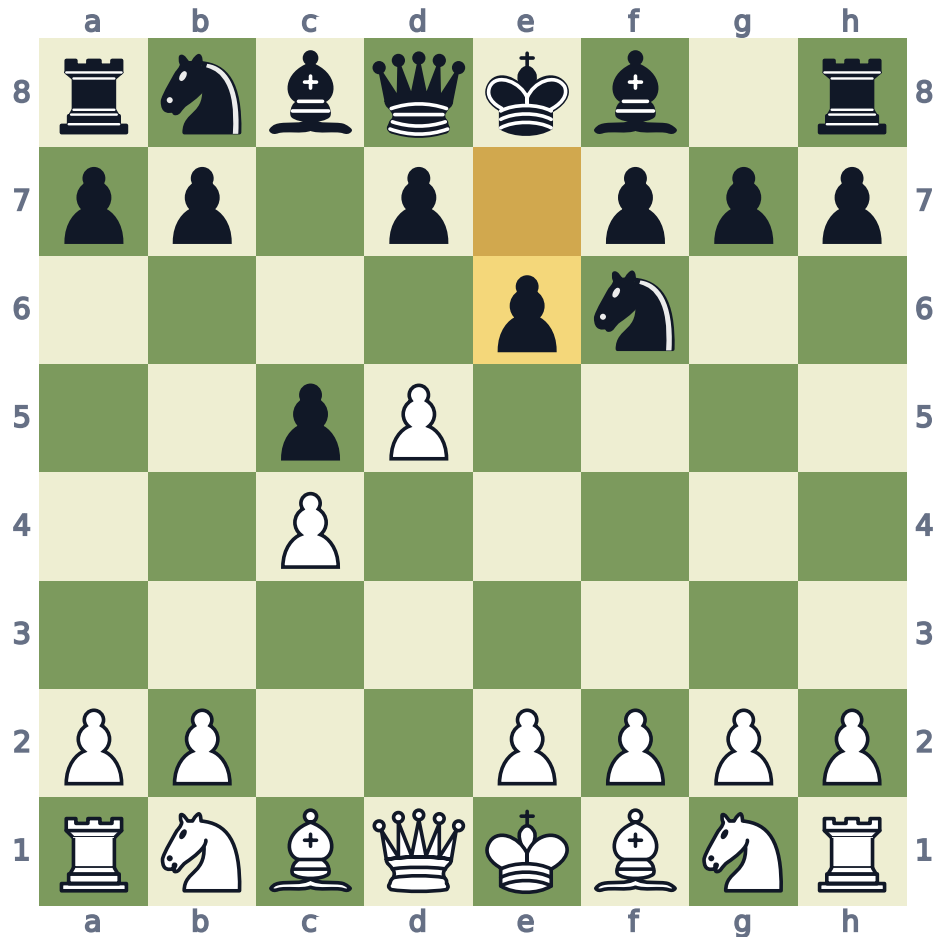
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 14 OF 36

Modern Benoni core

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

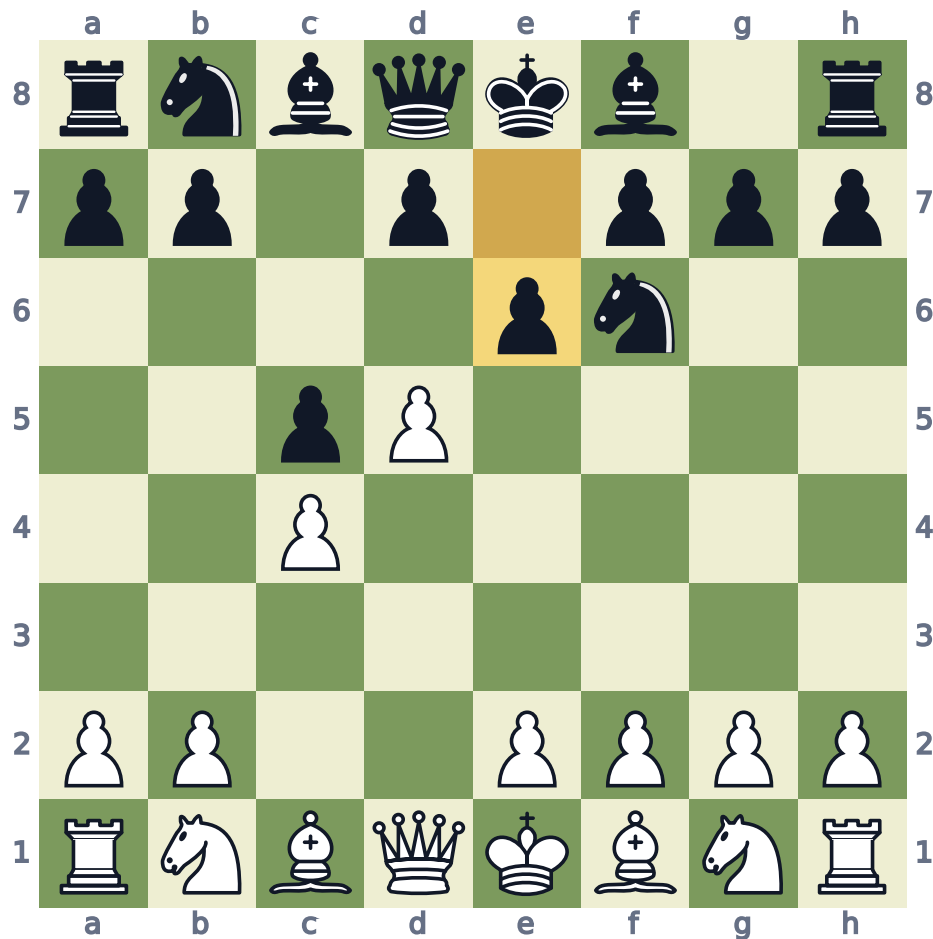
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 15 OF 36

Taimanov check



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

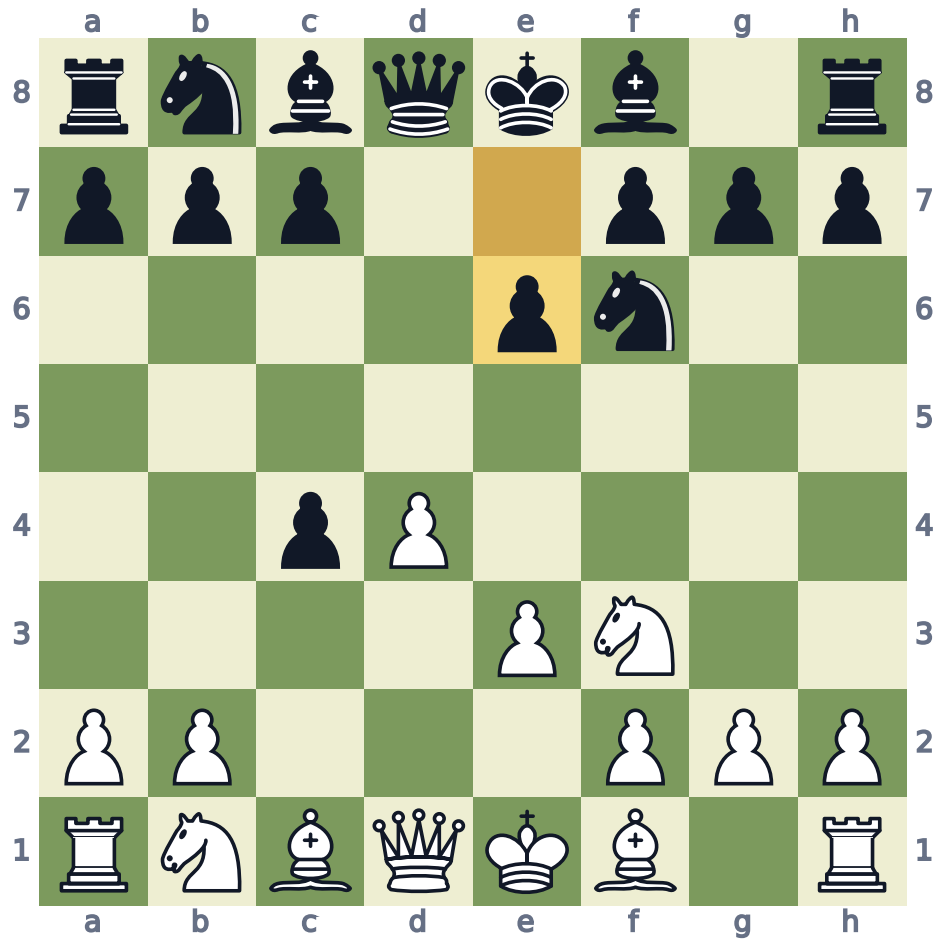
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 16 OF 36

QGA classical recovery

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

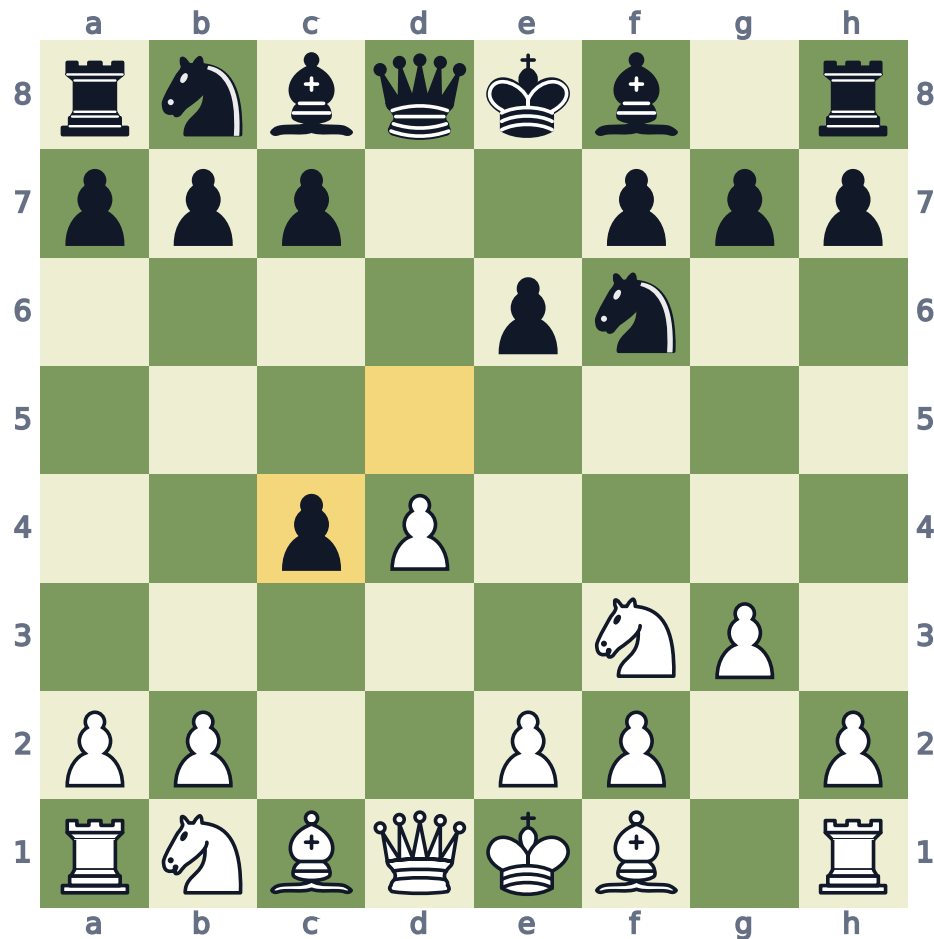
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 17 OF 36

Catalan endgame route

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 18 OF 36

KID with ...Nbd7

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 19 OF 36

Averbakh development

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

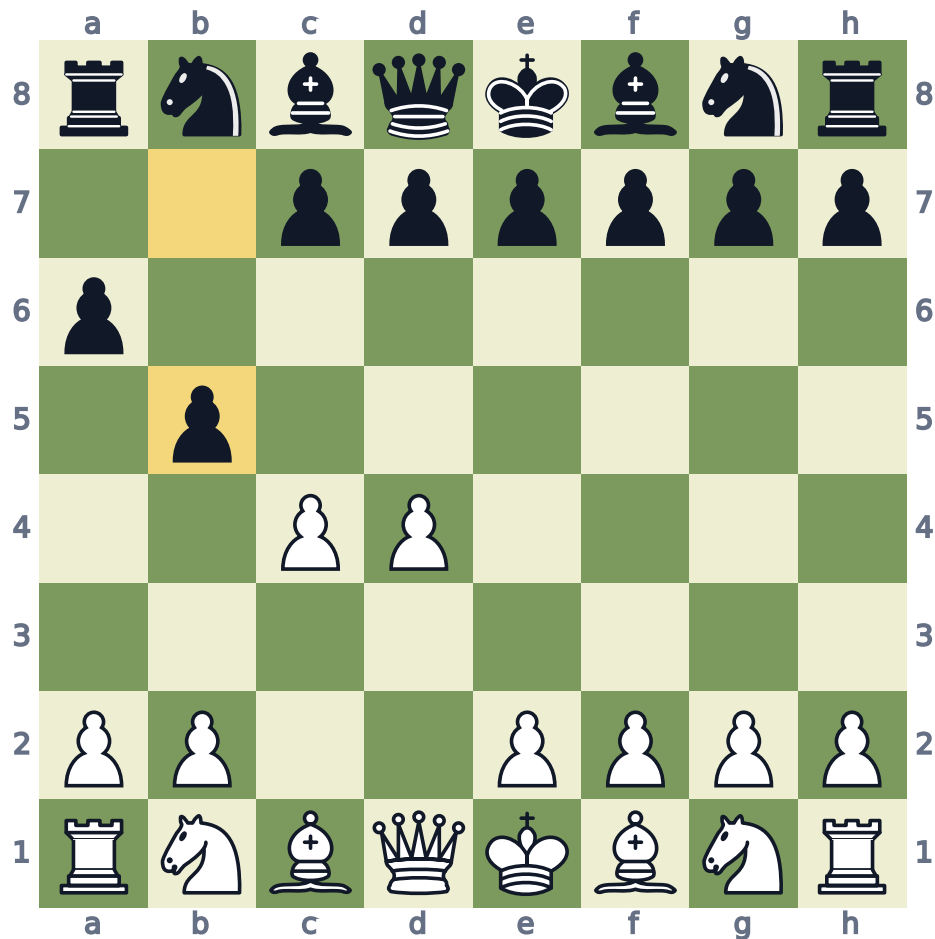
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 20 OF 36

1...a6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 21 OF 36

Exchange QGD core

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 22 OF 36

Development before expansion



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 23 OF 36

Central expansion setup



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 24 OF 36

Ragozin treatment

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 25 OF 36

Semi-Tarrasch

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

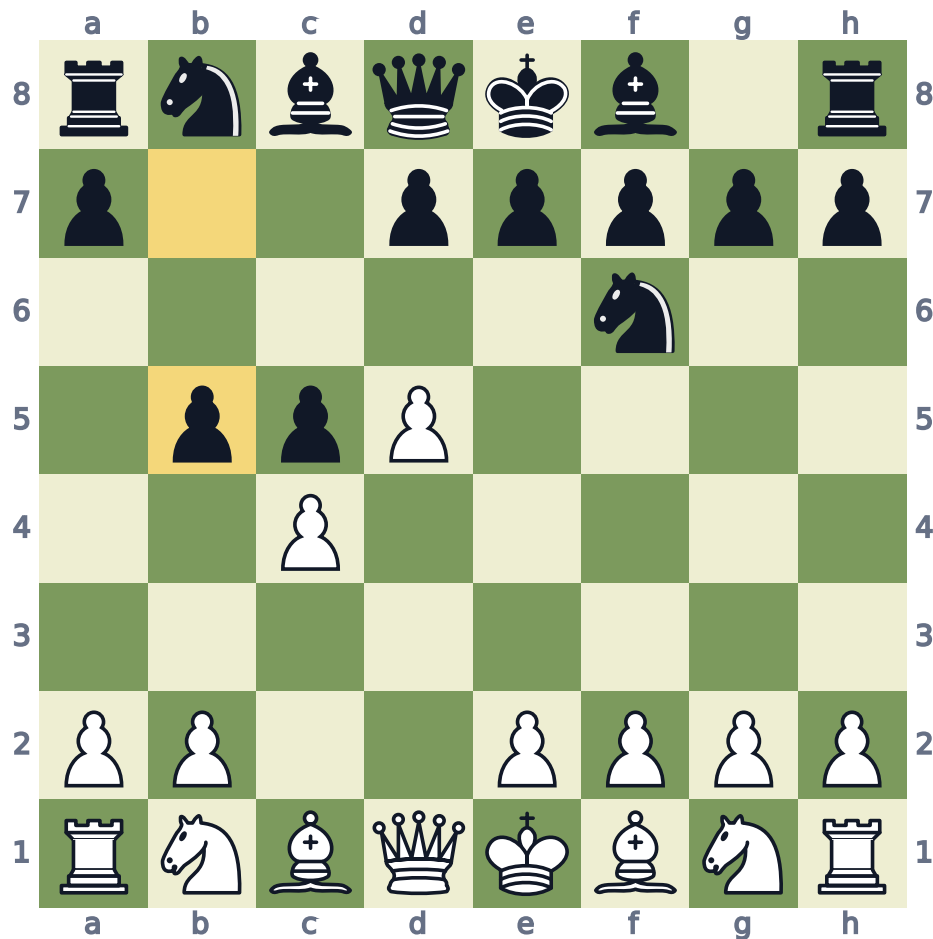
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 26 OF 36

Benko accepted

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 27 OF 36

Benko declined with b6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 28 OF 36

1...b5 Polish Defense

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 29 OF 36

Exchange Slav

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 30 OF 36

1...b6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 31 OF 36

QGA ...b5 expansion

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 32 OF 36

QGA central strike

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 33 OF 36

Open Catalan recovery



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 34 OF 36

Open Catalan with Qa4+

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 35 OF 36

Catalan ...Bb4+

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 36 OF 36

Catalan ...c5 challenge

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Tactical solutions begin here

SCORING HONESTY

A correct first move earns at most 2 points if the line or reason was missing. If the engine move differs from the repertoire move, record why: tactics, transposition, or a small positional preference. The goal is accurate thinking, not worship of a number.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 1-3

01. BLUMENFELD GAMBIT

Engine move: d5. Line: 1. d5 b5 2. dxe6 fxe6 3. cxb5 a6 4. Nc3 axb5 5. e4 b4. Evaluation: +0.76 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Return or consolidate material only after meeting Black's central activity. Warning: The e- and d-files can open against an uncastled king.

02. BENONI E5 BREAK

Engine move: cxd5. Line: 1. cxd5 d6 2. e4 g6 3. Bd3 Bg7 4. h3 O-O 5. Nf3 Re8. Evaluation: +0.76 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Support e4 and prepare f3 or Nc4 before driving with e5. Warning: e5 can leave d5 weak if the pieces cannot follow.

03. BENONI QUEENSIDE BREAK

Engine move: cxd5. Line: 1. cxd5 d6 2. e4 g6 3. Bd3 Bg7 4. h3 O-O 5. Nf3 Re8. Evaluation: +0.76 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Restrict ...b5 and make Black work for queenside counterplay. Warning: a4 creates b4 as an outpost and cannot be reversed.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 4-6

04. EARLY E4 IN THE QGA

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Bxd2+ 3. Nbx d2 exd4 4. Bxc4 Nc6 5. O-O Nge7. Evaluation: +0.38 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the broad center but accept simplification when Black checks and trades. Warning: The e-pawn can become a target if White falls behind in development.

05. ENGLUND GAMBIT

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 f6 2. Bf4 g5 3. Bg3 fxe5 4. Nxe5 Bg7 5. Nxc6 bxc6. Evaluation: +1.57 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Develop with tempo and be ready to return the pawn to trap or displace the queen. Warning: The b2-pawn is poisoned only if White knows the follow-up.

06. TARRASCH DEFENSE

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 Be7. Evaluation: +0.50 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Pressure the isolated d5-pawn while finishing development. Warning: Passive blockade lets Black use active piece play as compensation.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 7-9

07. FIANCHETTO ALTERNATIVE

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 d5 2. Qb3 c5 3. cxd5 cxd4 4. Nxd4 O-O 5. e4 Nxe4. Evaluation: +0.45 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Choose a lower-theory setup that contests the long diagonal and central squares. Warning: A slow setup can allow ...e5 and ...c6 without challenge.

08. CLOSED CATALAN CORE

Engine move: Bg2. Line: 1. Bg2 O-O 2. O-O dxc4 3. Qc2 c5 4. dxc5 Bxc5 5. Qxc4 Qb6. Evaluation: +0.47 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Complete the fianchetto and prepare e4 while the center remains closed. Warning: e4 without enough support can lose d4 or permit ...dxe4.

09. MINORITY ATTACK SETUP

Engine move: e3. Line: 1. e3 h6 2. Bh4 Bf5 3. Bxf6 Bxf6 4. Qb3 c5 5. Nge2 Be6. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Prepare b4-b5 to create a backward c6-pawn. Warning: Queenside play must not ignore Black's kingside or central break.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 10-12

10. ENGLISH DEFENSE

Engine move: e4. Line: 1. e4 Bb4+ 2. Nc3 Bb7 3. Bd3 Bxc3+ 4. bxc3 d6 5. Ne2 Qh4. Evaluation: +0.85 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Build the center but respect pressure on e4 and the long diagonal. Warning: An overextended center can be attacked by ...f5 and ...Bxc3+.

11. MARSHALL DEFENSE

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 Nb6 2. Nc3 g6 3. h3 Bg7 4. e4 O-O 5. Be2 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.95 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Take central space while answering the forcing check accurately. Warning: The broad center must be supported against ...c5.

12. BALTIC DEFENSE

Engine move: cxd5. Line: 1. cxd5 Bxb1 2. Rxb1 Qxd5 3. e3 e6 4. a3 Nd7. Evaluation: +0.84 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Use the queen check to regain time and finish development. Warning: The rook on b1 can become exposed along the b-file.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 13-15

13. BALTIC DEFENSE

Engine move: cxd5. Line: 1. cxd5 Bxb1 2. Rxb1 Qxd5 3. e3 e6 4. a3 Nd7. Evaluation: +0.84 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Exploit the early bishop move with a forcing check and development. Warning: The rook on b1 can be exposed if the b-file opens.

14. MODERN BENONI CORE

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 d6 3. h3 Bg7 4. Bd3. Evaluation: +0.95 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Use e4-f4 and prepare e5 while Black seeks queenside counterplay. Warning: The center can be attacked by ...Re8, ...b5, and tactics on e4.

15. TAIMANOV CHECK

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 d6 3. h3 Bg7 4. Bd3. Evaluation: +0.95 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Use the check to interfere with Black's development before castling. Warning: A check without a follow-up can merely improve Black's pieces.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 16-18

16. QGA CLASSICAL RECOVERY

Engine move: Bxc4. Line: 1. Bxc4 c5 2. O-O a6 3. dxc5 Bxc5 4. Qxd8+ Kxd8 5. Be2 Ke7. Evaluation: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Recover c4 through development and accept a clean active endgame. Warning: Do not fear queen trades when development and structure are healthy.

17. CATALAN ENDGAME ROUTE

Engine move: Bg2. Line: 1. Bg2 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 a5 3. a3 Bxd2+ 4. Qxd2 Nbd7 5. O-O O-O. Evaluation: +0.29 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Accept a long positional struggle and target queenside weaknesses after recovery. Warning: A pawn advantage is meaningless if Black keeps activity and files.

18. KID WITH ...NBD7

Engine move: e4. Line: 1. e4 O-O 2. Be2 d6 3. h4 h5 4. f3 Nc6 5. Be3 e5. Evaluation: +0.62 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Keep central tension and support e4 before deciding d5. Warning: A delayed d5 may permit ...exd4 and pressure e4.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 19-21

19. AVERBAKH DEVELOPMENT

Engine move: e4. Line: 1. e4 O-O 2. Be2 d6 3. h4 h5 4. f3 Nc6 5. Be3 e5. Evaluation: +0.62 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use Bg5 to reduce ...e5 or ...f5 options and keep the king flexible. Warning: Delaying Nf3 can expose d4 or e4 tactics.

20. 1...A6

Engine move: e4. Line: 1. e4 e6 2. cxb5 Nf6 3. Nc3 Bb7 4. Bg5 h6 5. Bxf6. Evaluation: +0.91 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Take the center and answer queenside expansion with development. Warning: Overreacting to a wing pawn wastes the central advantage.

21. EXCHANGE QGD CORE

Engine move: Bg5. Line: 1. Bg5 Be7 2. e3 O-O 3. Bd3 c5 4. Nge2 c4. Evaluation: +0.30 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Build toward f3 and e4 or a queenside minority attack. Warning: Do not play e4 until d4 and the king are secure.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 22-24

22. DEVELOPMENT BEFORE EXPANSION

Engine move: Bg5. Line: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5. Evaluation: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Prevent a free ...Bf5 or use queen pressure to question the bishop. Warning: Qf3 can be met by development with tempo if played carelessly.

23. CENTRAL EXPANSION SETUP

Engine move: Bg5. Line: 1. Bg5 Be7 2. e3 O-O 3. Bd3 c5 4. Nge2 c4. Evaluation: +0.30 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Prepare e4 with pieces and pawns coordinated behind it. Warning: f3 weakens dark squares and costs time; calculate ...c5.

24. RAGOZIN TREATMENT

Engine move: Bg5. Line: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5. Evaluation: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the exchange structure while meeting the pin without panic. Warning: The c3-knight may be pinned when central captures occur.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 25-27

25. SEMI-TARRASCH

Engine move: Bg5. Line: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5. Evaluation: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop around a flexible center and prepare to isolate or exchange Black's d-pawn. Warning: The symmetrical center can open suddenly after ...cxd4.

26. BENKO ACCEPTED

Engine move: cxb5. Line: 1. cxb5 a6 2. bxa6 e6 3. Nc3 exd5 4. Nxd5 Be7 5. Nf3 Nxd5. Evaluation: +0.63 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Consolidate the extra pawn while neutralizing files and the g7 bishop. Warning: The king and queenside can remain awkward for many moves.

27. BENKO DECLINED WITH B6

Engine move: cxb5. Line: 1. cxb5 a6 2. bxa6 e6 3. Nc3 exd5 4. Nxd5 Be7 5. Nf3 Nxd5. Evaluation: +0.63 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Avoid the full a- and b-file pressure and use the advanced b6 pawn as a cramping wedge. Warning: The pawn can become weak and Black may gain central tempi.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 28-30

28. 1...B5 POLISH DEFENSE

Engine move: Nd2. Line: 1. Nd2 b4 2. Ngf3 e6 3. Bd3 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. Re1 d6. Evaluation: +1.07 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Occupy the center and use tactics if Black attacks it prematurely. Warning: The sharp line requires exact checking geometry.

29. EXCHANGE SLAV

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 e6 2. Bf4 Nf6 3. e3 Nc6 4. Bd3 Bd6 5. Bxd6 Qxd6. Evaluation: +0.44 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use active piece placement and pressure the c-file in a symmetrical structure. Warning: Symmetry does not mean a draw; careless development can still concede initiative.

30. 1...B6

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 Nf6 2. Qc2 d5 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. e4 Nxc3 5. bxc3 e5. Evaluation: +0.75 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the same English Defense map and protect e4. Warning: The long diagonal can punish a careless d5 or e5 push.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 31-33

31. QGA ...B5 EXPANSION

Engine move: e3. Line: 1. e3 c5 2. Bxc4 e6 3. O-O a6 4. dxc5 Qxd1 5. Rxd1 Bxc5. Evaluation: +0.39 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Undermine the pawn chain rather than chase its front pawn. Warning: Opening the a-file can expose the rook if geometry is ignored.

32. QGA CENTRAL STRIKE

Engine move: e3. Line: 1. e3 c5 2. Bxc4 e6 3. O-O a6 4. dxc5 Qxd1 5. Rxd1 Bxc5. Evaluation: +0.39 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Complete development and be ready for dxc5 or e4. Warning: An automatic dxc5 can release Black's bishop with tempo.

33. OPEN CATALAN RECOVERY

Engine move: g3. Line: 1. g3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Be7 3. Qc2 O-O 4. Bg2 b6. Evaluation: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Recover c4 while preserving the bishop's diagonal and development lead. Warning: The queen on c4 can be chased by ...b5.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 34-36

34. OPEN CATALAN WITH QA4+

Engine move: g3. Line: 1. g3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Be7 3. Qc2 O-O 4. Bg2 b6. Evaluation: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the center and long diagonal to undermine Black's pawn chain. Warning: A premature axb5 can open useful files for Black.

35. CATALAN ...BB4+

Engine move: g3. Line: 1. g3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Be7 3. Qc2 O-O 4. Bg2 b6. Evaluation: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Meet the check with natural development and retain Catalan pressure. Warning: The bishop on d2 can obstruct queen pressure if left passive.

36. CATALAN ...C5 CHALLENGE

Engine move: g3. Line: 1. g3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Be7 3. Qc2 O-O 4. Bg2 b6. Evaluation: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Clarify the center when Black challenges before completing queenside development. Warning: Exchanges can release Black's isolated pawn activity.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.